

PROJECT AETHER

Design Patch Document — v3.1

Applies on top of Master Document v3.0

On any point of conflict, this document supersedes v3.0.

REVISION — Section 11: Skill System

The following replaces the Skill System section in v3.0 in its entirety.

The Three Layers — Unchanged

Layer	Source	Function
Weapon Type Skill Web	Weapon equipped	Passive node web per weapon type. Stat bonuses, scaling nodes, and skill slot structure. Three skill slots accepting Tomes.
Skill Tomes	Loot drops	Items socketed into skill slots. Each Tome grants one skill with a fixed base behavior. Build-defining eureka moment drops.
Slates	Loot drops	Modify and amplify everything established by the web and Tomes. The third and deepest layer. Slate modifiers reshape skill behavior through tag interaction.

Skill Slots & Tomes

Each weapon has three skill slots. Slots are empty until the player sockets a Skill Tome found as loot. Tomes are not auto-granted by weapon type — they are discovered, collected, and socketed by the player.

- 3 skill slots per weapon slot
- 6 skills minimum (two weapon slots filled)
- 9 skills maximum (all three weapon slots filled)
- Tomes can be swapped freely outside of combat

- Each Tome grants one skill with one fixed base behavior

How Skills Are Modified — The Slate Layer

Skills do not have multiple authored variants. Instead, behavioral variety emerges through Slate investment on the Fate Board. Slates with relevant tags carry modifiers that reshape skill behavior spatially and functionally.

Example — Flame Wall

Base behavior: Creates a stationary wall of fire at a targeted location. Applies Scorch on contact.

Through Slate investment:

- A Fire Slate modifier — 'Wall skills project in a circle around the caster' — reshapes Flame Wall into a surrounding ring of fire
- A Fire Slate modifier — 'Fire skills leave a burning trail during movement' — turns Flame Wall into a mobile fire trail
- A Spell Slate modifier — 'Wall skills apply Ignite on contact' — shifts the skill toward ailment application
- A Fire Slate modifier — 'Enemies affected by Wall skills have reduced movement speed' — adds a soft crowd control layer

The base skill is always the same. The player's Fate Board determines how it behaves in combat. Two players running Flame Wall can fight completely differently based on their Slate investment.

Skill Counts

- 3 skills per weapon slot
- 6 skills minimum (two weapon slots filled)
- 9 skills maximum (all three weapon slots filled)

Damage Formula — Unchanged

Final Damage = Base Weapon Damage x Motion Value x (Stat Scaling Grade Multiplier x Mastery Bonus)

- Motion values live on individual skills — never shown to the player as a number
- Low motion value — fast, chainable | High motion value — slow, committed, devastating
- Increased multipliers — additive, from Slates and gear

- More multipliers — multiplicative, rare, from skill web deep nodes and conditional moments

What the Skill Web Contains

The passive node web surrounding the three skill slots provides the statistical and scaling foundation for each weapon type. Specific web contents are to be designed per weapon type in a dedicated session. Framework:

- Stat nodes — flat bonuses to the relevant damage type's primary stat
- Scaling nodes — % increased damage for that weapon category
- Motion value nodes — increase the effective weight of committed attacks
- Skill interaction nodes — bonuses that trigger off specific skill behaviors (Wall skills, Channeled skills, etc.)
- Deep nodes — powerful conditional effects unlocked through heavy web investment

Specific web layouts per weapon type are deferred pending a dedicated design session.

ADDITION — New Unique Item: The Cartographer of Ruin

Added to the Unique & Mythic Items section. Unique item designs as a category remain deferred — this item is an exception generated during active design.

The Cartographer of Ruin

Rod — Unique | "He did not fight his way through the fortress. He simply decided where the walls would no longer be."

Property	Value
Base	Rod — High Spell Damage line, level 91 tier
Implicit	+13% increased Spell damage
Modifier 1	Throwables you use are treated as Spells for the purpose of Spell modifiers
Modifier 2	Grenades you throw leave a Scorch field at their detonation point for 4 seconds

Modifier 3	Enemies standing in a Scorch field take 40% increased Explosive damage from your Throwables
Modifier 4	Your Throwables have 35% increased Area of Effect
Modifier 5	25% chance to not consume a Throwable on use
Modifier 6	Spell Power is added to Throwable damage at 60% effectiveness
Build Problem	Scorch field requires enemies to be stationary or slowed — fast mobile enemies walk out before follow-up grenades land. Pairs with Black Hole, Caltrops, or Chill/Freeze effects.
Archetype	The Conduit Bomber — one of four Grenadier build expressions

ADDITION — Grenadier Build Category

Added to the Build Archetypes section under a new Throwable Specialist category.

Throwable Specialist Archetypes

Grenadier is not one build — it is a build category with four distinct valid expressions sharing an Explosive/throwable tag identity.

- The Conduit Bomber — Stays at range. Treats throwables as an extension of spellcasting. AoE extension, elemental riders, Scorch field setup. The Cartographer of Ruin is the defining Unique.
- The Melee Finisher — Uses grenades as setup, melee as payoff. Grenades break Composure, player closes in for a devastating follow-up. Pressure Fist or Mace identity.
- The Pure Throwable Specialist — Throwable as the centerpiece. Chain detonations, persistent ground effects, mechanically novel grenade behavior.
- The Heavy Artillery — Slow, massive, inevitable destruction. High motion value attacks that interact with Explosive status effects already applied to enemies.

Unique items for Melee Finisher, Pure Throwable, and Heavy Artillery expressions are deferred to the dedicated Unique design session.

ADDITION — Blind Status Effect (Deferred)

Added to the Deferred Design section.

Blind

Blind exists conceptually as a status effect but its mechanical expression is deferred. The core issue is that traditional accuracy reduction does not translate cleanly to action combat where enemy attacks are spatial hitbox events rather than statistical dice rolls.

Possible Directions — Not Locked

- Targeting disruption — Blinded enemies lose lock-on, attack in wrong directions, or hesitate
- Area denial — Blind creates a zone enemies refuse to enter or move through slowly
- Player screen obscuring — Smoke grenade obscures the player's own visibility, creating high risk/high reward positioning
- Item-referenced condition tag — Blind exists only as a tag other skills and Uniques reference ('Enemies that are Blinded take X') with no universal mechanical expression

Resolution deferred until core combat feel is established in playtesting. Mechanical expression to be determined once spatial hitbox behavior is validated.

UPDATES — Deferred Design Section

The following items are added to or updated in the Deferred Design section of v3.0.

Added to Deferred

- Skill web specifics per weapon type — framework locked, individual weapon webs require a dedicated design session
- Blind status effect mechanical expression — see addition above
- All Unique and Mythic item designs — deferred to a dedicated Unique design session. The Cartographer of Ruin is the only active Unique outside of the four examples in v3.0.
- Grenadier Unique items — Melee Finisher, Pure Throwable, Heavy Artillery expressions all deferred

Removed from Deferred

- Skill system Keystone structure — replaced by Option B (Slate behavioral modification). No longer under consideration in its original form.

Read alongside Master Document v3.0. On any point of conflict this patch supersedes. All values subject to revision after playtesting.